

Rhetorical technique - Study Guide

Explain how a writer uses examples, repetition, questions, contrast, anecdotes, statistics, or other techniques to influence meaning or emphasis.

Learning goal

Identify what a rhetorical choice accomplishes in context and connect the technique to the writer's purpose, argument, or reader response.

What this skill really means

Rhetorical techniques are choices writers use to make an idea clearer, more memorable, more credible, more urgent, or more persuasive.

The important task is usually not naming the technique. It is explaining what the technique does in this particular text.

A statistic can establish scale, an anecdote can make an issue concrete, repetition can emphasize a priority, a rhetorical question can challenge an assumption, and contrast can sharpen a difference.

Technique	Possible function	Evidence to check
statistic / data	show scale, frequency, trend, or evidence	number is relevant to a claim
anecdote / example	make an abstract issue concrete	specific person/event illustrates broader point
repetition	emphasize a phrase or priority	key wording intentionally repeated
rhetorical question	prompt reflection or challenge an assumption	question is asked for effect, not information

Technique	Possible function	Evidence to check
contrast	highlight a difference or change	before/after, expected/actual, one option vs another
analogy	explain unfamiliar idea through a familiar comparison	shared relationship or feature

How exam-style questions ask it

- What is the effect of the author's repetition of ___?
- Why does the author begin with the story of one resident?
- How does the statistic in paragraph 4 strengthen the argument?
- What does the rhetorical question encourage readers to consider?

A reliable method

1. Identify the technique or unusual choice.
2. Ask what idea surrounds it and what the writer is trying to accomplish there.
3. Explain the immediate effect: clarify, illustrate, emphasize, challenge, humanize, establish scale, create contrast.
4. Connect that effect to the larger purpose or argument.
5. Reject answers that name a technique but give an effect unrelated to the text.

Tips and shortcuts

- Complete the sentence: "The writer uses ___ to ___." The second blank matters more than the first.
- Do not assume every statistic makes an argument strong; it must actually support the relevant claim.
- A vivid anecdote can illustrate an issue without proving how common it is.

Worked examples

Example 1

"One missed bus can mean one missed shift. One missed shift can mean one smaller paycheck."

1. What is the effect of repeating "one missed"?

- A. It emphasizes how a small transportation problem can create a chain of consequences.
- B. It defines the word paycheck.
- C. It proves buses are always late.
- D. It changes the passage into a biography.

Answer: A

The repetition links each consequence and emphasizes how one disruption can lead to another.

Example 2

A letter argues for repairing a leaking community-center roof. It begins with a brief story about volunteers moving buckets during a children's class.

2. Why begin with the story?

- A. to give a concrete example of how the leak disrupts normal use
- B. to prove the roof is the oldest in the city
- C. to explain how buckets are manufactured
- D. to replace the need for any evidence about the roof

Answer: A

The anecdote makes the problem concrete by showing a real consequence, though it does not by itself prove every claim.

Common traps

- Naming the device without explaining its function.
- Claiming a technique proves more than it actually shows.

- Choosing a generic effect such as "makes the text interesting."
- Confusing emotional impact with logical evidence.

Self-check rule

Before accepting an answer, name the exact relationship between the target wording and the larger text. Point to evidence for that relationship, not just a familiar label.

Quick check

1. What does a statistic usually need in order to function as strong evidence?
2. Why is "makes the passage interesting" usually too vague?
3. Write a one-sentence explanation of what a rhetorical question can do.

Quick check guidance

Explain the relationship in plain language before using a technical label. If your explanation works only as a summary, ask what job, purpose, perspective, or effect is still missing.